E SIDE OF SEMAGLUTIDE

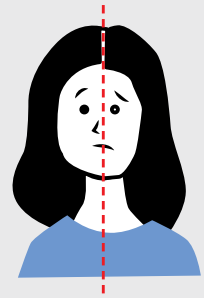


- Some patients may face ileus, a condition where the intestines lose their ability to contract, not allowing waste to move out of the body

- In rare cases, they can cause cancers of the medullary thyroid or the endocrine glands



- Losing weight too quickly can have a negative impact on muscle health. You may also get what is being called an Ozempic face, an Ozempic butt and Ozempic hair

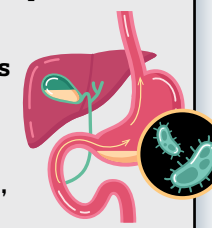


- If you stop the medicine and don't follow it up with lifestyle or dietary changes, the weight will most likely return. Cyclical losing or gaining of weight is not good for the body's cells



- There is no data yet to ascertain the impact of off-label use in non-diabetic or non-obese/overweight people

- There have been no trials of Indians in Indian settings. The BMI and body shape of Indian diabetics are different from their western counterparts



- Nutritionists and gut specialists believe it can harm gut flora, causing long-term digestion and health issues. We also don't know the long-term impact of slowed-down digestion on the stomach, intestinal or colon cells

- Its price remains prohibitive, with Rybelsus costing approximately Rs 1.2 lakh a year

Illustrations by **TANMOY CHAKRABORTY**

and lost three kilos in a month.

Indiscriminate use of the drug is only making things worse. The lack of prescription audits in India means there is no way to ascertain if drugs are being sold illegally without a prescription, says Dr Sharad Agarwal, national president of the Indian Medical Association. Calling the trend dangerous, Jayaseelan J., vice-president of the Indian Pharmaceutical Association, says, "All medicines have side-effects and must be taken with factual knowledge and supervision." Both patient and doctor need to be educated. Patients need to understand that nutrition, fitness, sleep and being stress-free are as critical to weight loss as any drug. Doctors, too, need to be educated about the pros and cons of any new drug. "Doctors," says Jayaseelan, "are not pharmacologists. They know the effect of a drug and how to use it, but not to the extent that a pharmacologist does. The pharmacists' role needs to be better defined in India." In the US, for example, the prescription is not given to the patient at all but sent to the pharmacist, who then dispenses the medicine with full information about it, its use and its impact.



"DOCTORS DO USE ORAL SEMAGLUTIDE FOR NON-DIABETICS SINCE WE DON'T HAVE WEGOVY HERE AND WE ALSO DO NOT HAVE ANY EFFECTIVE MEDICATION FOR OBESITY, A MAJOR HEALTH CONCERN"

DR RICHA CHATURVEDI
Senior consultant, Endocrinology, Indraprastha Apollo Hospital

Being new, there is no data yet on the long-term impact of these drugs. In a 2022 literature review to identify oral semaglutide approval, guidelines and clinical evidence in the journal *Science Direct*, it was found that there was no data on the medicine in an Indian clinical setting. The two major studies done to prove the impact and negative impact of semaglutide and tirzepatide have been sponsored by the companies who created them. Independent trials are few and far between. There is also no research to show whether these drugs are useful for the non-obese or non-diabetics. Despite the efforts towards body positivity, we remain a society obsessed with thinness. "I see patients who see imperfections where none exist all the time," says Dr Amit Gupta, a Mumbai-based plastic surgeon and director of Divine Aesthetics. "As doctors, it is our